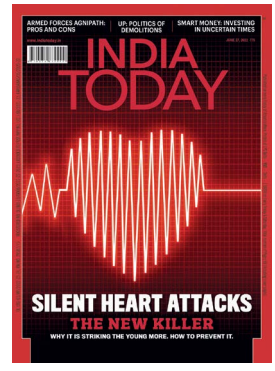
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

There is always much talk about the health of the heart, and we obsess over the same recycled points every time we hear about another person dying of a heart attack. More attention should be paid to the condition of our gut. It's a critical upstream department for all vital organs. Take the hormone serotonin, for instance. Known to act as a universal pick-me-up crucial for a range of functions like mood regulation, sleep, digestion and cognition, it also plays a key part in a number of cardiac phenomena. And about 95 per cent of serotonin is synthesised in the gut, from dietary protein. Global research is now finding a series of such strong links between the gut and a range of bodily phenomena. Scientists are therefore tracing a whole variety of illnesses, both physical and mental, back to their point of origin in the gut. That makes gut health a first priority.

Fortunately for us, the Indian gut is unique. An exhaustive 2019 study that compared 1.55 million microbial genes in the Indian gut with the global catalogue found that nearly one million genes were unique to us. These distinct gut flora give us rare advantages: Indians generally demonstrate a reduced incidence of Irritable Bowel Syndrome (IBS) and colon cancer. "We do not realise just how much we should be grateful to our microbiota," says Dr Uday C. Ghoshal, president-elect of the Indian Society of Gastroenterology. That's the good part. The bad news is that urban life is fast eroding the advantage that Indians had. We are ruining our gut with reckless consumption of food containing ultra-processed flour, chemical additives and villains like sugar and excess salt and devoid of fibre. A 2023 survey found that an alarming seven out of 10 urban Indians experience gut health issues, 60 per cent of them weekly. Not surprisingly, 63 per cent of the respondents also ate junk or processed food. An earlier study found that 22 per cent of Indians suffer from functional constipation, more so in the metros, with the condition being increasingly seen among children. Now we have reason to link all of this and sedentary living to the spike in 'lifestyle diseases' at one end and psychological ailments at the other.



June 27, 2022

It is easier to understand that metabolic disorders are linked to the gut. It turns out that an entire array of cognitive phenomena, too, are born in the stomach, the small intestine and the colon. So much so that the gut, especially its complex neural system, is being rechristened as our 'second brain', a composite organ. This unfolding discovery is not merely an incremental scientific advance; it's a paradigm shift. The complex ways our digestive tract 'talks' to our head is now seen as a complete communication system called the 'gut-brain axis'. This weakens primarily because of a chronic impoverishment of our gut microbiota, a condition called 'dysbiosis', in which the rich species variety of bacteria and other life forms that generally inhabit our gut comes down drastically. The known effects now range from anxiety disorder to clinical depression. "Inflammation in the gut can trigger neuroinflammation, leading to mental health issues. Dysbiosis may also be linked to neurological conditions like anxiety, depression and neurodegenerative diseases," says Dr Harsh Seth, a gastrointestinal surgeon associated with Mumbai's Wockhardt Hospitals. So conditions like Parkinson's and Alzheimer's are being researched vis-à-vis a possible origination in an impoverished gut. Links are also being established to autoimmune diseases, endocrinal disorders, cardiovascular diseases and cancer. Examine the ominously rising graph of all those in India, and you will appreciate the magnitude of the problem.

But all these discoveries also open up a fascinating gamut of potential future therapy options by putting the gut front and centre of our attention. Some 70 per cent of our 'gut flora' lives in the colon, a lesser number in the small intestine and much lesser still in the stomach, whose acidic environment is not too salubrious as a habitat. However, gut health is no longer linked only with constipation, irritable bowels, or acid reflux, though they remain key markers. What happens in the small and large intestines is now recognised as the beginning of a cascade of vastly subtler events, like sensory perception, autonomic functions like the heart's pulsing action, concentration, emotional resilience and psychological well-being. So, scientists are paying considerable attention to the balance of species in our gut flora. As the word gets around, a range of gut reset formulations, including a well-rounded array of probiotics and prebiotics, have flooded the market. Tests to check our gut health are beginning to take on the urgency once reserved only for ECGs. Procedures such as faecal transplants are producing astonishing results. And the new popularity of fermented foods like kefir, kimchi, sauerkraut and our humble dahi turns out to be not based on just a faddish fancy but on sound reason.

Senior Editor Sonali Acharjee, who wrote this exhaustive cover story on the importance of gut health, brings not only precise and straightforward explanations as to why your gut is misbehaving but also practical tips and the latest treatment options. It's time to junk that notion of a duality between the mind and the body. The older holistic views seem to have had the correct intuition. So tweak that proverb: trust your gut, but treat it well.

(Aroon Purie)